

Reflection:

In comparing Voyant and GPT, I began to see that machines “read” in fundamentally different ways depending on their design. Voyant treats meaning as pattern. It breaks the text into data points by analyzing word frequency, repetition, collocations, and distribution across the text. This approach uncovers structural features of texts that are difficult to notice through close reading alone. For example, seeing which words repeat can highlight major themes or tonal shifts. Voyant makes the text visible as a system. However, it does not interpret why those patterns matter. It cannot distinguish irony from sincerity or understand emotional nuance unless a human reader steps in to assign significance. GPT, by contrast, treats meaning as a relationship and context. Instead of counting words, it synthesizes them into arguments. It reads for coherence and implication. GPT can explain how a symbol functions or how a character’s actions reflect broader social tensions. Yet this fluency can also obscure its limitations. Because it produces smooth interpretations, it might seem authoritative, even if its analysis is based on random linguistic patterns.

These machines are very useful and can reveal hidden patterns and quickly generate interpretive frameworks for us. At the same time, though, relying on these tools can distance us from the slower, more reflective engagement that characterizes human interpretation. Voyant constructs meaning through frequency and distribution, while GPT constructs meaning through contextual synthesis and narrative explanation. Placed side by side, they demonstrate that interpretation is always mediated, and that the method of reading fundamentally shapes what counts as meaning.

Attribution & AI Use:

- **Text used** - The Present By: Phil Cosker, <https://philcoskerwriter.com/2021/04/18/the-present/>
- **Tools used:** Voyant, ChatGPT
- **GPT prompt(s):** Can you give me a literary analysis of this short story: (then I pasted the whole text into the prompt)
- **What each tool could *not* do:** Voyant could not interpret the actual meaning of the words beyond patterns, while ChatGPT could not transparently show the data or evidence behind its interpretive claims.